Chapter Two

Birth of the State of Israel

"Palestine is the cement that holds the Arab world together, or it is the explosive that blows it apart."

—Yasser Arafat

On May 14, 1948, in a ceremony held at the Tel Aviv Museum, David Ben-Gurion, executive head of the World Zionist Organization and chairman of the Jewish Agency for Palestine, announced the creation of a Jewish homeland to be known as the State of Israel. This new state would come into being at midnight as the British mandate expired. Soon after, Ben-Gurion became the first prime minister of the new state.

The declaration of the State of Israel included one notable issue: it did not clearly define the territorial boundaries of the new nation. It noted only a willingness on the part of the new state to negotiate based on the territorial division defined by the UN resolution. However, many Jewish people, including Prime Minister Ben-Gurion, saw no reason not to expand the territory of Israel into the areas designated as Arab by the UN. After all, the Palestinians had refused to accept the terms of that resolution anyway, and it seemed almost certain that Israel would soon be attacked by its Arab neighbors, so if it could seize additional territory, why should that too not become part of Israel?

At just eleven minutes after midnight on May 15, the United States became the first nation to recognize the new state. It was quickly followed later the same day by other nations, including Guatemala, Nicaragua, Uruguay, Iceland, and Romania. On May 17, Israel was formally recognized by the Soviet Union and by countries of the Eastern Bloc, including Czechoslovakia, Poland, and Yugoslavia.

A major issue facing the new state was the condition of its army. The troops who had fought for Haganah were quickly incorporated